

ShiftCare — User Handbook

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1. What is ShiftCare?

ShiftCare is an AI-powered shift-coverage assistant for home-care agencies.

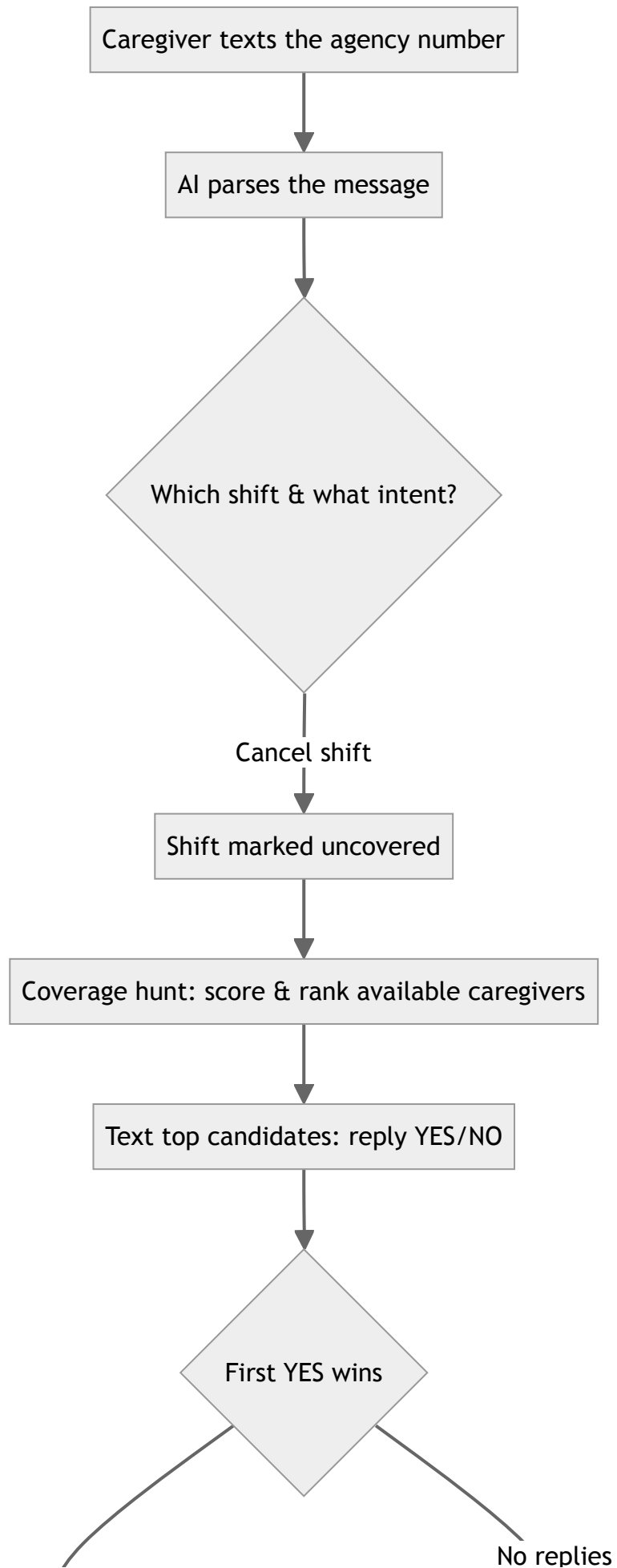
When a caregiver can't make a shift, they simply **text the agency in plain English** — "Hey it's Maria, I'm sick, can't make my 9am." ShiftCare reads the message with AI, figures out which shift they mean, automatically hunts for the best available replacement, texts candidates, claims the shift for whoever replies **YES** first, and notifies the client's family and the agency owner — all without a human coordinator lifting a finger.

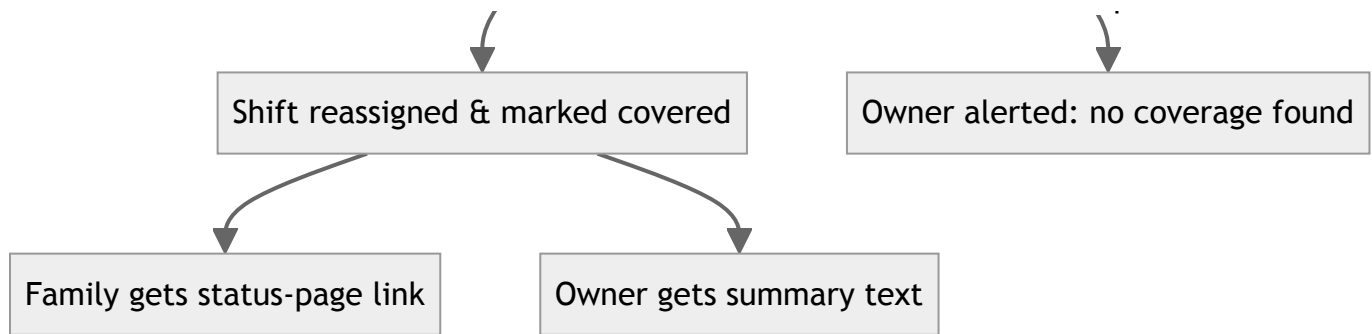
It replaces the frantic phone-tag that normally happens when a caregiver calls out, and it keeps everyone — the agency, the caregivers, and the families — in sync automatically.

Who it's for

Role	What they get
Agency owner / coordinator	A live dashboard, an admin panel to manage people and shifts, a full message history, and automatic coverage without phone-tag.
Caregivers	Text-to-cancel, automatic coverage offers, plus a self-service employee portal (schedule, clock-in/out, pay, availability).
Client families	A private status page (texted to them automatically) showing who's coming, when, and live shift status — no login needed.

2. How it works (the core flow)





1. A **caregiver texts** the agency's phone number (powered by Telnix).
2. **AI reads the intent** — is this a cancellation, a YES, a NO, or something else? It also extracts the **time** ("9am") and **date** ("tomorrow", "Friday") from the message.
3. If it's a **cancellation**, the shift is flipped to `uncovered` and the **coverage hunt** begins.
4. ShiftCare **scores every available caregiver** (see §5) and texts the best matches a coverage request.
5. The **first caregiver to reply YES** claims the shift (race-safe — only one person can win, even if two reply at the same instant).
6. The **family** automatically receives a link to a live status page, and the **owner** gets a one-line summary.
7. If **nobody is available or nobody replies**, the owner is alerted immediately so they can step in.

3. Getting started

3.1 Signing in (agency owner / coordinator)

1. Go to the ShiftCare site (production: `https://web-production-13d30.up.railway.app/`).
2. Click **Sign in** in the top navigation.
3. Enter your username and password.
4. You'll land on the **Dashboard** (today's schedule).
5. Click **Admin Panel** → (top-right of the dashboard) to reach the full management area.

3.2 The two main areas

- **Dashboard** (`/dashboard`) — a read-only, auto-refreshing (every 30s), color-coded view of a single day's shifts. Use the **← Prev / Next →** links to move between days.
 - **Admin Panel** (`/admin/...`) — the full management console with a sidebar: Caregivers, Clients, Shifts, Coverage Log, **Messages**, and Inquiries.
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4. The Admin Panel — feature by feature

Section	What you do there
 Caregivers	Add, edit, or remove caregivers. Set phone, ZIP code, certifications, pay rate, availability, and <code>max shifts/day</code> . Also opens the caregiver portal setup.
 Clients	Add, edit, or remove care recipients. Set address, care notes, family phone, and any required certifications for that client.
 Shifts	Create, edit, and delete shifts (date, start/end time, caregiver, client). This is where the schedule is built.
 Coverage Log	A dated history of every coverage event — who cancelled, who was contacted, who claimed the shift. Filter by date.
 Messages	The full two-way SMS history, grouped into conversation threads by phone. See exactly what every caregiver and family texted, with role badges (caregiver / family).
Inquiries	Contact-form submissions from the public website.

Key admin tips

- **Every caregiver needs availability set.** A caregiver with empty availability will be *filtered out of every coverage hunt*. Set weekday windows (e.g. Mon–Fri 8am–6pm) so they can be matched.
- **A shift needs both a start and end time.** A shift with a missing start time can't be matched to anyone during a coverage hunt.
- **Required certifications on a client** boost matching accuracy — caregivers who hold those certs are scored higher for that client's shifts.

5. How coverage matching works (the scoring)

When a shift needs coverage, ShiftCare looks at every caregiver who is:

- **Active**,
- **Available** in their stated hours for that weekday and time window,
- **Not already** at their `max shifts/day` limit (default **2**),
- **Free** of a conflicting shift at that time.

Each eligible caregiver is then **scored**, and the highest scorers are contacted first:

Points	Reason
+30	Caregiver's ZIP code matches the client's preferred ZIP (proximity)
+20	Per required certification the caregiver holds
+5	Per past shift they've already covered for that same client (familiarity)
+2	Generalist bonus — holds extra certs beyond what's required

This means the closest, best-qualified, most-familiar caregiver is offered the shift first.

6. What caregivers can text (SMS commands)

Caregivers don't need an app to interact — plain English works. The AI recognizes four intents:

Intent	Example messages	What happens
Cancel a shift	"I'm sick, can't make my 9am", "won't be in tomorrow", "calling out Friday"	Their shift is released and coverage hunt starts.
Accept coverage	"YES", "I can take it", "sure"	They claim the offered shift (first YES wins).
Decline coverage	"NO", "can't tonight"	They're skipped; the next candidate is offered.
Other	anything unrelated	Logged, no automated action.

Multi-shift clarification: If a caregiver has more than one shift and doesn't say which one they mean, ShiftCare texts back to ask, then remembers the answer (conversation memory with a 30-minute window).

Security: Texts from phone numbers not in the caregiver list are ignored — no reply, no action.

7. The Caregiver (Employee) Portal

Caregivers get their own self-service portal at `/employee/login`.

Logging in (two-factor)

1. Enter **phone number + password**.
2. ShiftCare texts a **6-digit code** (valid 10 minutes).
3. Enter the code to finish signing in. *(5 wrong attempts locks the attempt; codes expire after 10 minutes.)*

What caregivers can do

Portal page	Purpose
Dashboard	Today's shift, upcoming shifts, this week's stats, and a Clock in / Clock out button.
Shifts	Upcoming shifts + this month's completed shifts with hours and earnings. Tap a shift for full detail (client, address, care notes, clock times).
Pay	Week / month / year-to-date earnings, plus downloadable pay stubs per pay period.
Profile	Update availability (per-weekday time windows) and change password.

Clocking in sets the shift to `active` ; **clocking out** sets it to `covered` and records hours for pay.

8. The Family / Client Portal

When a shift is confirmed, the client's family automatically receives a **text with a private link** to a status page (`/client/<token>`):

- **No login required** — the link itself is the key.
 - Shows the **caregiver's name, arrival time, care notes, and live shift status**.
 - Gives families peace of mind without any phone calls.
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9. Shift statuses at a glance

Status	Color	Meaning
scheduled	Yellow	Assigned and upcoming; nobody has clocked in yet.
active	Green	Caregiver has clocked in; shift in progress.
covered	Green	Completed, or successfully re-covered after a cancellation.
uncovered	Red	Caregiver cancelled and no replacement yet — needs attention.
cancelled	Gray	Shift called off entirely.

10. Behind the scenes (technical overview)

For administrators and developers maintaining the system.

Component	Technology
Web app	Python + Flask (<code>app.py</code>)
AI intent parsing	Anthropic Claude (Haiku) via <code>ai_parser.py</code> , with a heuristic fallback
Coverage logic	<code>coverage.py</code> — search, score, notify, claim
Database	SQLite locally, PostgreSQL in production (<code>db.py</code>)
SMS	Telnyx (primary), with Twilio and Vonage supported (<code>sms.py</code>)
Hosting	Railway (auto-deploys from GitHub <code>main</code>)

Important environment variables

Variable	Purpose
<code>SMS_PROVIDER</code>	Which SMS gateway to use (<code>telnyx</code> , <code>twilio</code> , <code>vonage</code>).
<code>TELNYX_API_KEY</code> / <code>TELNYX_FROM</code>	Telnyx credentials and the agency's sending number.
<code>ANTHROPIC_API_KEY</code>	Enables AI message parsing.
<code>DRY_RUN_SMS</code>	<code>1</code> = log messages instead of sending (safe testing); <code>0</code> = live.
<code>DATABASE_URL</code>	Postgres connection string in production.
<code>BASE_URL</code>	Domain used when building family-portal links.
<code>ADMIN_PASSWORD</code>	Admin panel password (if used).

Safety tip: Keep `DRY_RUN_SMS=1` while testing so no real texts (or SMS charges) go out. Switch to `0` only for live operation.

11. Common tasks — quick reference

I want to...	Do this
Add a new caregiver	Admin Panel → Caregivers → New. Be sure to set availability .
Add a new client	Admin Panel → Clients → New. Add family phone + required certs.
Schedule a shift	Admin Panel → Shifts → New. Set date, start/end time, caregiver, client.
See today's schedule	Dashboard (auto-refreshes every 30s).
Review who was contacted for coverage	Admin Panel → Coverage Log (filter by date).
Read the full SMS history	Admin Panel → Messages .
Let a caregiver self-serve	Point them to <code>/employee/login</code> .
Test without sending real texts	Set <code>DRY_RUN_SMS=1</code> .

12. Troubleshooting

Symptom	Likely cause & fix
A caregiver never gets coverage requests	Their availability is empty or doesn't cover that weekday/time. Set it in Admin → Caregivers (or they set it in their portal Profile).
Coverage hunt finds nobody	Shift may be missing a start time , or no caregiver is available/qualified. Check the shift and caregiver availability.
Texts aren't sending	Check <code>DRY_RUN_SMS</code> (should be <code>0</code> for live), the <code>TELNYX_FROM</code> number is one your account actually owns, and the API key is set.
A caregiver's text does nothing	Their phone number isn't in the caregiver list, or it doesn't match the stored format. Confirm the number in Admin → Caregivers.
Owner gets "no coverage found" every time	Usually empty availability across caregivers or a bad shift time — see the two rows above.

ShiftCare — coverage that texts itself.